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Volume XXXIII Number 42; For the week Oct 14-20, 2008, released on Oct 13

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Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia New Delhi

Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301;

Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and

Fardabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080;

e-mail: ircare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to

General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Connaught House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,

New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor,

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prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press

India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana);

A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, district Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and

at Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Alroli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra);

Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.

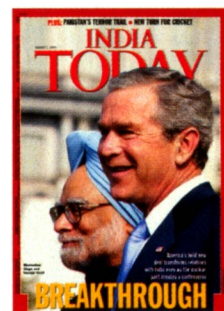
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INDIA TODAY has assiduously tracked the Indo-US nuclear deal since it was announced by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and US President George W. Bush on July 18, 2005. We featured the event on our cover, calling it "Breakthrough". Since then we followed this roller coaster nuclear saga for over three years, putting it on our cover eight times.

Simply put, this deal was designed to end India's 34-year nuclear isolation following the Pokhran Test of 1974. The deal offered India a way out, even while allowing it to retain its nuclear weapons option. Bush was willing to expend considerable amounts of political capital to amend his own country's laws prohibiting civilian nuclear trade to countries that hadn't signed the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty like India and asking the 45-member Nuclear Suppliers Group for a special waiver for India. Bush has a simple functioning principle of "you are either for us or against us". Fortunately, India was in the 'for' category. It is to Bush's credit, and he doesn't have many, that he pushed through this audacious deal with tenacity.

Both Manmohan and Bush met with much resistance to the deal. For Bush, the US Congress, influenced strongly by the ayatollahs of non-proliferation in Washington DC, threatened to derail the deal. Manmohan's main opposition came from the UPA's allies on the Left. He seemed to have developed cold feet and almost dropped the ball when the Left threatened to withdraw support to the UPA. At the time I wrote that the prime minister had "lost his nerve, his spine, his conviction and now his place in history".



Our Aug 2005 cover

But Manmohan surprised everyone by subsequently standing up to the Left, putting his Government on the line and winning, albeit dubiously, a trust vote in Parliament. Since then it has been a race against time but the deal is finally signed and sealed.

The biggest benefit of this deal could come in a most critical area—electricity. India faces a severe shortage of power and our civilian nuclear energy programme has faltered. A shortage of uranium during the years of isolation has meant that India's nuclear power plants, capable of generating 4,100 MW, are functioning only at 50 per cent capacity. The deal will allow us to purchase reactors from overseas and in five years, add 10,000 MW of power—twice the amount it has taken 50 years to do on our own.

Our cover story on the prospects of the nuclear deal has been put together by Managing Editor Raj Chengappa, who has followed the deal since its inception. Says Chengappa, "It's a sweetheart deal."

The nuclear deal has defined Manmohan's premiership. When the dust settles, both Bush and Manmohan, I am glad to say, will take their rightful place in history.

Aron Purie
(Aron Purie)